

Formality weakening and the underspecified expressive *yo* in Korean

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1. Introduction¹

Potts (2005, 2007) discusses in detail the notion of expressives and how they denote something distinct from at-issue semantics. One defining property of expressives is repeatability: the iteration of an expressive signals a gradual heightening of one's emotional state. The Korean formality-denoting marker *si* nicely illustrates this point (Kim & Sells 2007):²

- (1) *pro* kong-ul capa-po-ci mos-ha-si-ess-ta.
3.SG ball-ACC catch-try-CI NEG-do-SI-PST-DECL
'(S)he wasn't able to catch the ball.' (↪ formal)
- (2) *pro* kong-ul capa-po-si-ci mos-ha-si-ess-ta.
3.SG ball-ACC catch-try-SI-CI NEG-do-SI-PST-DECL
'(S)he wasn't able to catch the ball.' (↪ more formal)

Choe (2004) notes that the increase of formality due to the repetition of *si* is an instance of formality strengthening. This is in tandem with the nature of repeatability.

Unlike ordinary formality-denoting expressives, however, the multiple realization of *yo* in Korean triggers the opposite effect of strengthening. (3)–(5) share the same descriptive content: 'Lee met Kim.' The presence of the sentence-final *yo* in (3) allows the speaker to convey a sense of formality to the addressee.³ The addition of a sentence-medial *yo* in (4) weakens the level of the expressive content and the addition of a secondary medial *yo* in (5) further undermines it. Note, however, that the cutback never amounts to zero and a sense of formality is preserved even in (5).⁴

¹ My greatest thanks go to Chris Barker, Philippe Schlenker, and WooJin Chung. This work would not have been possible without them. I would also like to thank Elin McCready, Hiroki Nomoto, and the audience at LSA 2021 for their valuable comments. All remaining errors are my own.

² In Korean, various terms such as politeness and honorifics have been adopted to characterize formality. For present purposes, I wish not to make a fine-grained distinction among these terms.

³ I briefly note that sentence-final *yo* conveys less formality than many other formality-denoting markers in Korean. However, this does not mean that final *yo* is used in informal contexts: a sentence with final *yo* conveys more formality than the baseline sentence without a formality marker.

- a. Lee-ka Kim-ul manna-ss-e.
Lee-NOM Kim-ACC meet-PST-DECL
'Lee met Kim.' (↪ baseline: formality valued at 0)
- b. Lee-ka Kim-ul manna-ss-e-yo.
Lee-NOM Kim-ACC meet-PST-DECL-F.YO
'Lee met Kim.' (↪ formal: formality valued above 0)

All else being equal, final *yo* does trigger a sense of formality although its effect may be subtle.

⁴ Medial and final *yos* behave like clitics: (i) they can attach to various grammatical categories without actually changing the category and (ii) they can attach to phrases instead of words (see Yim & Dobashi 2016, 2018):

- (3) Lee-ka Kim-ul manna-ss-e-yo.
 Lee-NOM Kim-ACC meet-PST-DECL-F.YO
 ‘Lee met Kim.’ (↗ formal)
- (4) Lee-ka Kim-ul-yo manna-ss-e-yo.
 Lee-NOM Kim-ACC-M.YO meet-PST-DECL-F.YO
 ‘Lee met Kim.’ (↗ less formal)
- (5) Lee-ka-yo Kim-ul-yo manna-ss-e-yo.
 Lee-NOM-M.YO Kim-ACC-M.YO meet-PST-DECL-F.YO
 ‘Lee met Kim.’ (↗ least formal)

Despite what is known about repeatability in the literature (Potts 2007; McCready 2019), the weakening effect induced by medial *yo*s in Korean remains unexplored. To my knowledge, this phenomenon has not been analyzed with theoretical scrutiny (Lee & Park 1991; Yim & Dobashi 2016, 2018). Thus, I argue that (6) is an additional type of repeatability.

- (6) Weakening: each use of the expressive makes what it initially expresses weaker
 (example: medial *yo* in Korean)

Quite interestingly, medial *yo*s can perform a weakening effect on a formality marker other than the final *yo*. (7)–(9) have the same descriptive content as (3)–(5): ‘Lee met Kim.’ The marker (*su*)*pni* triggers formality in (7). The realization of medial *yo*(s) in (8) and (9) triggers the weakening effect observed in (4) and (5). Note that the final *yo* is not realized in these examples:⁵

- (7) Lee-ka Kim-ul manna-ss-supni-ta.
 Lee-NOM Kim-ACC meet-PST-PNI-DECL
 ‘Lee met Kim.’ (↗ very formal)
- (8) Lee-ka Kim-ul-yo manna-ss-supni-ta.
 Lee-NOM Kim-ACC-M.YO meet-PST-PNI-DECL
 ‘Lee met Kim.’ (↗ less formal)
- (9) Lee-ka-yo Kim-ul-yo manna-ss-supni-ta.
 Lee-NOM-M.YO Kim-ACC-M.YO meet-PST-PNI-DECL
 ‘Lee met Kim.’ (↗ least formal)

In the absence of the final *yo* or (*su*)*pni*, however, medial *yo*s cannot be realized in the derivation. Hence, medial *yo*s are dependent on other formality-denoting expressives.⁶

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- a. [XP Lee-wa*(-yo) Kim-i]-yo wa-ss-e-yo.
 [XP Lee-and Kim-NOM]-M.YO come-PST-DECL-F.YO
 ‘Lee and Kim came.’

Further, there may be a non-trivial correlation between formality weakening and the elevation of some other content such as engagement or hesitation when medial *yo*s are used in different discourse settings (see Lee & Park (1991) for an overview on these various discourse effects). While I recognize this form of dynamicity, the focus of this work is to provide an account for the formality weakening effect displayed by medial *yo*s.

⁵ A naturally occurring sentence hosting a medial *yo* and (*su*)*pni* is provided below:

- a. Sinmwun-un-yo capdongsani-ka ani-pni-ta.
 newspaper-TOP-M.YO junk-NOM NEG-PNI-DECL
 ‘Newspapers are not junk.’ (Korean National Corpus; MBC 100 Minute Debate)

⁶ Medial *yo*s can only be licensed by formality markers that reflect the speaker’s attitude towards the addressee.

- (10) *Lee-ka-yo Kim-ul manna-ss-e/ta.
 Lee-NOM-M.YO Kim-ACC meet-PST-DECL
 Intended: ‘Lee met Kim.’

Here, I argue that medial *yos* are underspecified in terms of their expressive content and therefore must be accompanied by another formality-denoting marker that can fill in the gap.⁷ This work will address which information medial *yos* lack in particular and how this issue can be properly resolved.

The purpose of this work is two-fold. First, I address a pattern of repeatability which has been understudied in the literature (Lee & Park 1991; Yim 2012): the iterative use of *yo* in Korean weakens the strength of formality. Second, I argue that not all expressives are fully specified in nature.

The organization of this work is as follows: Section 2 examines whether medial and final *yos* qualify as expressives using Potts’s (2007) diagnostics. Section 3 discusses a theoretical approach to handling the underspecificity and the weakening effect of medial *yos*. Section 4 explores whether medial *yos* display properties of indexicals. Section 5 concludes.

2. Medial and final *yos* as expressives

In this section, I mainly show that medial and final *yos* satisfy all of the properties Potts (2007) assumes for expressives, except for one, namely repeatability, which we focus much of our attention on throughout this work. In addition to the typological observation made by McCready (2019), I elaborate on why the weakening effect should be a subclass of repeatability.

2.1 Expressive properties

First, let us go over each of the expressive properties and examine whether they are compatible with medial and final *yos*. Under Potts’s (2007) scrutiny, expressives exhibit six major properties: (a) independence, (b) nondisplaceability, (c) perspective dependence, (d) descriptive ineffability, (e) immediacy, and (f) repeatability.

Independence shows that the descriptive meaning, which is truth conditional, is separate from the expressive meaning, which is non-truth-conditional. To illustrate, (11) conveys two different sources of meaning which cannot be readily unified.

- (11) The honkies received all the credit.
- Descriptive: The white people received all the credit.
 - Expressive: The speaker has a bad opinion about the white people.

The same can be said about (12). Its descriptive content and expressive content cannot be readily unified.

- (12) Sonnim-i-yo wa-ss-e-yo.
 guest-NOM-M.YO come-PST-DECL-F.YO
- Descriptive: The guest came.
 - Expressive: The speaker is being a bit formal to the addressee.

Formality markers other than final *yo* and (*su*)*pni* such as *nim* (nominalizer), *pwun* (classifier), *kkeyse* (nominative case), and *si* may reflect the speaker’s attitude towards a referent who is not the addressee. These particles along with other discourse markers, be it informal or non-formal, do not have a medial *yo* counterpart and thus cannot display the weakening effect.

⁷ Elin McCready (p.c.) mentions that this phenomenon could be viewed as a kind of presupposition failure at the expressive level. While this idea seems very interesting, I leave much of the discussion for future research.

Nondisplaceability shows that expressives predicate something of an utterance situation (see also McCready 2019). Hence, expressives outscope operators internal to an utterance. To give a comparison, the non-expressive *despised white people* in (13a) cannot scope over the past tense operator *yesterday* and thus a contradiction is not observed. However, the expressive *honkies* in (13b) must scope over the past tense operator *yesterday* and thus a contradiction is observed in the second sentence:

- (13) a. The despised white people received all the credit yesterday. (But they are not despised today, because today they received no credit.)
 b. The honkies received all the credit yesterday. (#But they are not honkies today, because today they received no credit.)

Medial and final *yos* also display this property. That is, they scope over tense operators. (14) contains two sentences denoting events in two different time settings: (i) the first sentence denotes an event in the past, whereas (ii) the second sentence denotes an event in the present. If medial and final *yos* in the first sentence display nondisplaceability and must scope over past tense operators such as *ecey* ‘yesterday’, the following sentence leads to a contradiction: the speaker is conveying formality but is at the same time conveying informality. This prediction is borne out:

- (14) Ecey sonnim-i-yo wa-ss-e-yo. (#cey-ka cikum cokum
 yesterday guest-NOM come-PST-DECL-F.YO (1.SG-NOM now a.bit
 mwulye-ha-key mal-hay-ss-ney(-yo))
 rude-ADJ-KEY say-do-PST-NEY(-F.YO).)
 • Descriptive: The guest came yesterday. (I was being a bit rude/informal just now.)
 • Expressive: The speaker is being a bit formal to the addressee. (#The speaker is a bit rude/informal to the addressee.)

The embedding of *yo* under an attitude verb also yields the same effect. (15) shows that medial *yo* realized inside the embedded clause scopes over the matrix attitude verb *think*.⁸ This is consistent with the idea that the expressive content should be independent from the descriptive content. (16) is contradictory in that medial *yo* must scope over a direct-quoted embedded clause, which traps scope-taking elements within its domain.

- (15) John-i ecey sonnim-i-yo wa-ss-ta-ko sayngkak-hay-yo.
 John-NOM yesterday guest-NOM-M.YO come-PST-DECL-C think-do-F.YO
 • Descriptive: John thinks that the guest came yesterday.
 • Expressive: The speaker is being a bit formal to the addressee.
 (16) #John-i ‘ecey sonnim-i-yo wa-ss-ta’-lako sayngkak-hay-yo.
 John-NOM yesterday guest-NOM-M.YO come-PST-DECL-C think-do-F.YO
 • Descriptive intended: John thinks ‘the guest came yesterday’.
 • Expressive intended: The speaker is being a bit formal to the addressee.

Expressives reflect the emotion or the attitude of a particular individual, which is subject to **perspective dependence**. The expressive in (17) conveys the speaker’s emotion towards a particular group of individuals, namely *the white people*. As noted above, the expressive content cannot convey the emotion of any random individual:

⁸ Philippe Schlenker (p.c.) mentions that the impossibility of semantically embedding expressives under attitude verbs in English is at least debated.

(17) The honkies received all the credit.

- Descriptive: The white people received all the credit.
- Expressive: The speaker(/#someone other than the speaker) has a bad opinion about the white people.

Medial and final *yos* share this property. That is, they always reflect the speaker's attitude towards the addressee and no one else.

(18) Sonnim-i-yo wa-ss-e-yo.

guest-NOM-M.YO come-PST-DECL-F.YO

- Descriptive: The guest came.
- Expressive: The speaker(/#someone other than the speaker) is being formal to the addressee(/#someone other than the addressee).

Expressive contents cannot be adequately paraphrased in truth-conditional terms. This property is referred to as **descriptive ineffability**.⁹ Instead of defining them in descriptive terms, Potts (2007) uses *expressive index*, which hosts a real-numbered interval (**I**):

(19) An *expressive index* is a triple $\langle a \textbf{I} b \rangle$, where a and b are in the domain of entities and $\textbf{I} \subseteq [-1, 1]$. (Potts 2007:177)

In $\langle a \textbf{I} b \rangle$, a and b may be represented as the speaker and the addressee of a conversation or a referent that the two interlocutors have in mind. When $\textbf{I} \subseteq [0, 1]$, positivity is conveyed. When $\textbf{I} \subseteq [-1, 0]$, negativity is conveyed. As for $[-1, 1]$, no expressive contribution is available as it encompasses all possible **I**s. With the expressive index, the semantics of the following sentences may be represented as (20) and (21) (*[referent]*¹⁰ in (20) refers to *the white people*):

(20) The honkies received all the credit.

- Descriptive: The white people received all the credit.
- Expressive: $\langle [\textit{speaker}] [-1, 0] [\textit{referent}] \rangle$

(21) Ce salam-i tangkun-ul an mek-e-yo.

that person-NOM carrot-ACC NEG eat-DECL-F.YO

- Descriptive: That person doesn't eat carrots.
- Expressive: $\langle [\textit{speaker}] [0, 1] [\textit{addressee}] \rangle$

Is are flexible enough to be overwritten by **I**s of other expressives. **Immediacy**, another property of expressives, ensures that the overwriting process cannot take away the content which has already been uttered. This is because the effect of an expressive is immediate and cannot be undone. However, it is possible to make the content more specific by overwriting **I**s *within* the range of their initial real-numbered figures (e.g., $[0, 1]$ (initial **I**) $\Rightarrow [0.5, 1] \Rightarrow [0.75, 1]$).¹¹ Epithets and formality-denoting markers are no exceptions.

The final defining property of expressives is **repeatability**: the iteration of an expressive signals a gradual heightening of one's emotional state.

⁹ Geurts (2007) mentions that descriptive ineffability is not a decisive property of expressives. For present purposes, I wish to emphasize that defining expressives without a descriptive content *is* possible. This does not necessarily imply that all expressives are descriptively undefined. I leave much of the broader discussion for future research.

¹⁰ In this work, I use square brackets to indicate expressive entities and real-numbered intervals (**I**s). Double square brackets indicate lexical entries (see section 3.2).

¹¹ I will discuss in detail how the overwriting process works for medial *yos* in section 2.2.

(22) Repeatability

If a speaker repeatedly uses an expressive item, the effect is generally one of strengthening the emotive content, rather than one of redundancy. (Potts 2007:167)

This property is observed when the overwriting process of **I** takes place possibly multiple times. Potts (2007) provides (23) as an example of repeatability. The multiple realization of *damn* induces the desired strengthening effect:

- (23) a. Damn, I left my keys in the car.
b. Damn, I left my damn keys in the car.
c. Damn, I left my damn keys in the damn car. (Potts 2007:182)

The multiple realization of *yo*, on the other hand, does not elevate the level of its expressive content (see also Choi 2021). Rather, the opposite effect holds. Recall that (3)–(5) showcases this effect. They are repeated below:

- (24) Lee-ka Kim-ul manna-ss-e-yo.
Lee-NOM Kim-ACC meet-PST-DECL-F.YO
'Lee met Kim.' (↗ formal)
- (25) Lee-ka Kim-ul-yo manna-ss-e-yo.
Lee-NOM Kim-ACC-M.YO meet-PST-DECL-F.YO
'Lee met Kim.' (↗ less formal)
- (26) Lee-ka-yo Kim-ul-yo manna-ss-e-yo.
Lee-NOM-M.YO Kim-ACC-M.YO meet-PST-DECL-F.YO
'Lee met Kim.' (↗ least formal)

Little has been discussed in the literature on how the overwriting process works for non-strengthening effects. In the next subsection, I present one way of addressing the overwriting process for the weakening effect induced by medial *yos*.

2.2 The weakening effect induced by medial *yos*

In addition to the general mechanism discussed in section 2.1, I introduce two key concepts for capturing the weakening effect displayed by medial *yos*. First is the double downarrow $\Downarrow$ which indicates the decrease in the level of formality. Second is the operator $+n$ which indicates the actual number of iteration present in the derivation. Putting these two together, I represent the overwriting process as $\Downarrow_{+n}$:

- (27) a. Ce salam-i tangkun-ul an mek-e-yo.
that person-NOM carrot-ACC NEG eat-DECL-F.YO
• Descriptive: That person doesn't eat carrots.
• Expressive: $\langle [speaker][0, 1][addressee] \rangle$
- b. Ce salam-i tangkun-ul-yo an mek-e-yo.
that person-NOM carrot-ACC-M.YO NEG eat-DECL-F.YO
• Descriptive: That person doesn't eat carrots.
• Expressive: $\langle [speaker][0, 1]\Downarrow_{+1}[addressee] \rangle$
- c. Ce salam-i-yo tangkun-ul-yo an mek-e-yo.
that person-NOM-M.YO carrot-ACC-M.YO NEG eat-DECL-F.YO
• Descriptive: That person doesn't eat carrots.
• Expressive: $\langle [speaker][0, 1]\Downarrow_{+2}[addressee] \rangle$

The mean value of the initial **I** is taken to be the maximum value of the overwritten **I**. Similarly, the mean value of the updated **I** is taken to be the maximum value of the next overwritten **I**. The process repeats itself each time a medial *yo* is added to the derivation. I take into account that certain discourse cues may bias the outcome of **I**. Potts (2007:178) mentions that facial gestures, hand gestures, posture, tone, and pitch are some potential factors inducing these biases. He posits that **I** is designed to accommodate these uncertainties. I incorporate the variable β which reflects any biases present in the context. When an instance of non-truth-conditional semantics is subject to repeatability, β adjusts **I** accordingly. That is, β , which can be a positive or a negative value, adds or subtracts the minimum or the maximum value in order to reflect the discourse situation. (28) illustrates how this mechanism works.

- (28) The overwriting process of the weakening effect in **I** terms
 $[\min_1 + \beta, \max_1 + \beta] \Rightarrow [\min_1 + \beta, \max_2 + \beta] \Rightarrow [\min_1 + \beta, \max_3 + \beta] \dots \Rightarrow [\min_1 + \beta, \max_n + \beta]$
 $\Rightarrow \max_2 = (\min_1 + \max_1)/2$
 $\Rightarrow \max_3 = (\min_1 + \max_2)/2$
 $\dots$
 $\Rightarrow \max_n = (\min_1 + \max_{n-1})/2$

Applying (28) to $\mathbf{I} \downarrow_{+n}$ in (27a)–(27c) yields (29a)–(29c). Here, I take β to be 0 ($\beta = 0$) as no discourse bias is specified.¹²

- (29) a. (27a) **I**: [0, 1] (no overwriting process)
b. (27b) **I**: [0, 1] $\downarrow_{+1} = [0, (0+1)/2] = [0, .5]$
c. (27c) **I**: [0, 1] $\downarrow_{+2} = [0, (0+1)/2] \downarrow_{+1} = [0, .5] \downarrow_{+1} = [0, (0+.5)/2] = [0, .25]$

(29) captures three essential qualities of medial *yos*. First, the minimum and the maximum values of an overwritten **I** are contained within their initial threshold (e.g., [0, 1] in the case of (27)). Contrast this with an unconstrained subtractive system which may produce nonexisting values such as -100 and -1000 . Second, the overwriting process is by and large autonomous. That is, reference to external sources other than the number of iteration (i.e., $+n$) is unnecessary. Due to this autonomy, defining expressive contents can be simplified (see section 3.2 for more discussion). The mechanism captures another significant characteristic of repeatability. That is, the n th round of iteration brings a greater impact to its expressive content than the $n+1$ th round. Compare the drop of formality between (29a)–(29b) and (29b)–(29c). The gap between the two maximum values of the former is greater than that of the latter. Simply put, the decline in formality becomes subtler as more iterations are applied to the derivation.

While *yo* exhibits many of the properties defined in Potts (2007), repeatability seems to be one exception. In fact, McCready (2019) posits that Potts’s definition of repeatability is not entirely adequate when data from Thai and Japanese are given consideration. I argue alongside McCready and assume that more needs to be articulated about the effect(s) of repeatability. McCready classifies repeatability into three subclasses. Here are some examples: (i) The multiple use of *damn* triggers a strengthening effect as we saw in (23). (ii) The multiple use of *sensei* ‘teacher’ preserves its expressive content without strengthening it. McCready classifies this type of phenomenon as ‘reinforcement’. (iii) The expression *good morning* is not considered to be repeatable by virtue of its meaning: one can only greet once. McCready assumes that a single use of the expression is enough to convey the full potential of its content and thus iteration is by no means necessary in an ordinary setting.

¹² For convenience, β is set to 0 by default.

(30) (McCready 2019:134)

- a. Strengthening: each use of the expressive makes what it expresses stronger (example: *damn* in English)
- b. Reinforcing: each use of the expressive keeps what it expresses salient (example: *sensei* in Japanese)
- c. Unrepeatable: repetition induces infelicity (example: *good morning* in English)

Despite McCready's typological survey, the weakening effect induced by medial *yos* has not been reported. Hence, I propose (31), which is repeated from (6), as a new subclass of repeatability.

(31) Weakening: each use of the expressive makes what it initially expresses weaker (example: medial *yo* in Korean)

In the next section, I explore theoretical ways of defining medial and final *yos* and examine the nature of the weakening effect in greater detail.

3. Lexical entries and the analysis

In this section, I introduce McCready's (2019) analysis on defining formality-denoting expressives. McCready's approach is most suitable for analyzing Thai and Japanese discourse markers, but it can also be used to characterize the roles of Korean expressives including medial and final *yos*. Based on McCready's assumption, I provide details on how the weakening effect in Korean may be represented in lexical entry terms.

3.1 Thai formality markers *khá* and *kháp*

McCready (2019) provides lexical entries for various expressives in Thai and Japanese. Among these discourse particles, the formality-denoting markers *khá* and *kháp* in Thai closely resemble Korean final *yo* in three crucial ways: (i) they are vacuous in terms of descriptive content, (ii) they represent the speaker's attitude towards the addressee, and (iii) they are realized at the end of a sentence. Consider (32) and (33):

(32) Fǒn dtòk khá

rain fall POL.PT

- Descriptive: It's raining
- Expressive: The feminine speaker is being formal to the addressee.

(Thai, McCready 2019:45)

(33) Mii gaafɛ kháp

exists coffee POL.PT

- Descriptive: There is coffee.
- Expressive: The masculine speaker is being formal to the addressee.

(Thai, McCready 2019:47)

Type specification of expressive contents differs from that of descriptive contents (Potts 2005, 2007; McCready 2019). Type-theoretically, this is to separate the composition of the two, since they are not semantically composable. McCready (2019) labels the descriptive type as σ^a and the expressive type as σ^s (σ is a metavariable).¹³ A language-specific feature of Thai that relates

¹³ According to McCready (2019), type denotation itself (*a* or *s*) is not crucial. What is important, however, is the type distinction made between the descriptive and the non-descriptive contents.

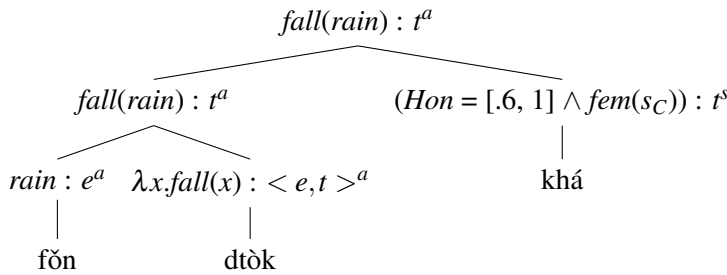
to our discussion is gender specification. Quite interestingly, *khá* is used to express femininity whereas its counterpart, *kháp*, is used to express masculinity. McCready specifies the former as $fem(s_C)$, denoting a feminine speaker of the context, and the latter as $mas(s_C)$, referring to a masculine speaker of the context. Under this system, the semantics of *khá* and *kháp* are represented as (34) and (35), respectively:

(34) Lexical entry for *khá* in Thai
 $\llbracket khá \rrbracket^C = (Hon = [.6, 1] \wedge fem(s_C)) : t^s$ (McCready 2019:46)

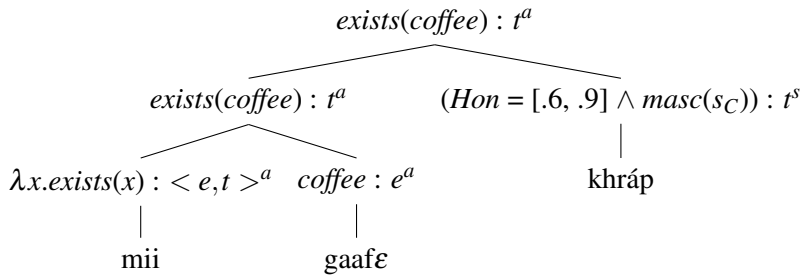
(35) Lexical entry for *kháp* in Thai¹⁴
 $\llbracket kháp \rrbracket^C = (Hon = [.6, .9] \wedge masc(s_C)) : t^s$ (McCready 2019:46)

For derivational clarity, I provide semantic trees with type specifications for (32) and (33):

(36) Tree derivation for (32)



(37) Tree derivation for (33)



Note that t^a and t^s do not compose. In other words, they do not interact. Hence, the output semantics given in (38) and (39) represents the descriptive content and the expressive content on separate grounds:

(38) Output semantics of (32)
 $\langle fall(rain), \{Hon = [.6, 1], fem(s_C)\} \rangle$ (McCready 2019:47)

(39) Output semantics of (33)
 $\langle exists(coffee), \{Hon = [.6, .9], masc(s_C)\} \rangle$ (McCready 2019:47)

The expressive semantics for (38) is valid if a feminine speaker is conveying formality to the addressee and **I** is defined as [.6, 1]. The expressive semantics for (39) is valid if a masculine speaker is conveying formality to the addressee and **I** is defined as [.6, .9].

McCready introduces additional apparatuses for handling lexical items conveying both expressive and descriptive contents referred to as mixed contents. Japanese honorific copulas such as *desu* and *gozar* fall under this category (McCready 2019:49).¹⁵ Further elaboration on mixed

¹⁴ The maximum value of *kháp* is capped off at .9 because there is a particle in Thai that conveys a higher level of formality, namely *kháp-phǒm*.

¹⁵ Korean honorific nominalizer *nim* and honorific classifier *pwun* may also be viewed as mixed contents.

contents, however, need not be introduced in this work, since the weakening effect of formality in Korean only applies to items that are purely non-descriptive (e.g., *yos* and *(su)pni*). Hence, I adopt McCready’s core analysis on expressive contents leaving out much of the discussion on mixed contents.

3.2 Korean formality markers

Adopting McCready’s general analysis on *khá* and *kháp*, I provide (40) and (41) as the lexical entries for final and medial *yos*, respectively.¹⁶ Here, I specify the interlocutors, namely the speaker and the addressee, in order to better represent the *expressive index* given in section 2.1. F labeled above **I** refers to formality:

- (40) Lexical entry for final *yo*
 $\llbracket yo_{\text{final}} \rrbracket = ([\text{speaker}][0, 1]^F[\text{addressee}]) : t^s$
- (41) Lexical entry for medial *yo* ($\mathbb{I}^F$ is underspecified)
 $\llbracket yo_{\text{medial}} \rrbracket = ([\text{speaker}]\mathbb{I}^F \Downarrow_{+1}[\text{addressee}]) : t^s$

The lexical entry given in (40) can be applied to (42) and (43). They yield nearly the same output as (38) and (39) in part by aligning the expressive content next to the descriptive content:

- (42) pi-ka nayli-e-yo
rain-NOM fall-DECL-F.YO
 $\langle \text{fall}(\text{rain}), \{[\text{speaker}][0, 1]^F[\text{addressee}]\} \rangle$
- (43) khephi-ka iss-e-yo
coffee-NOM exist-DECL-F.YO
 $\langle \text{exists}(\text{coffee}), \{[\text{speaker}][0, 1]^F[\text{addressee}]\} \rangle$

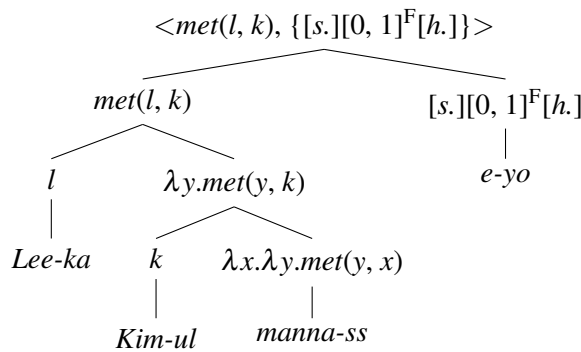
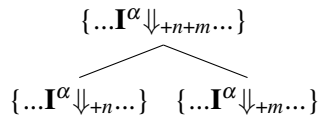
In order to derive the weakening effect, more needs to be articulated. The lexical entry for medial *yo* given in (41) showcases this effect.¹⁷ As mentioned in section 2.2, $\Downarrow$ indicates the decrease in expressive strength and $+n$ indicates the number of iteration in the derivation. Crucially note that $\mathbb{I}^F$ is underspecified for medial *yos* unlike final *yo*. The lexical entries (40) and (41) capture the fact that final and medial *yos* take on different roles: Final *yo* generates formality whereas medial *yo* takes away a portion of formality. The division of labor correctly predicts the weakening effect observed in (45) and (46) as well as the absence of the effect in (44).

- (44) Lee-ka Kim-ul manna-ss-e-yo.
Lee-NOM Kim-ACC meet-PST-DECL-F.YO
‘Lee met Kim.’ ($\leadsto$ formal)
- (45) Lee-ka Kim-ul-yo manna-ss-e-yo.
Lee-NOM Kim-ACC-M.YO meet-PST-DECL-F.YO
‘Lee met Kim.’ ($\leadsto$ less formal)
- (46) Lee-ka-yo Kim-ul-yo manna-ss-e-yo.
Lee-NOM-M.YO Kim-ACC-M.YO meet-PST-DECL-F.YO
‘Lee met Kim.’ ($\leadsto$ least formal)

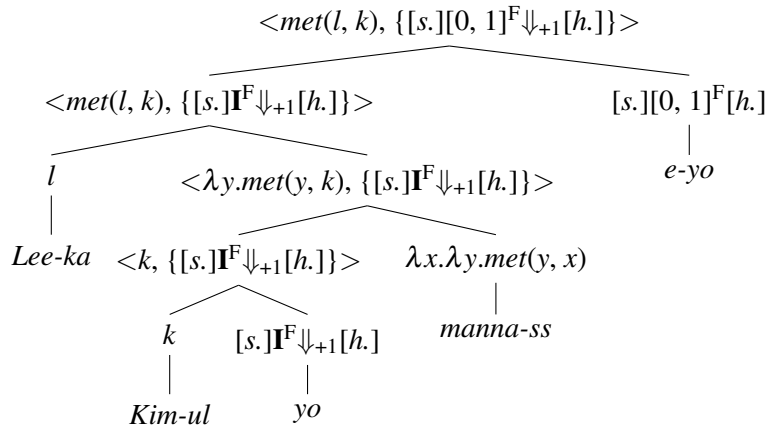
¹⁶ I leave out gender specification, since final and medial *yos* do not specify gender identity.

¹⁷ Yim & Dobashi (2018) also distinguish medial *yo* from final *yo*. They recognize the meaning difference between the two, but little is mentioned about the actual semantics of medial *yos*. Here, I wish to fill in the gap.

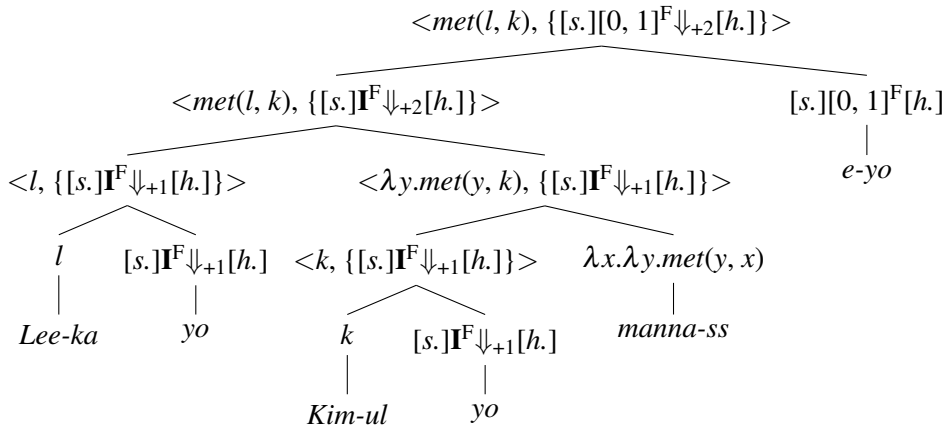
For clarity, I provide a step-by-step derivation for (44)–(46).¹⁸ I align the expressive content next to the descriptive content in each step of the derivation if there is one. [*speaker*] and [*addressee*] are abbreviated as [*s.*] and [*h.*] and the type specifications of the descriptive and expressive contents (e.g., σ^a and σ^s) are omitted for simplicity. Lastly, I provide the following rule to sum up the number of iterations used in a given derivation (see (50) on how this rule is applied to an actual example). The mother node adds up the operators $+n$ and $+m$ of its daughter nodes in a compositional fashion.¹⁹



(49) Tree derivation for (45)



(50) Tree derivation for (46)



After the trees are built compositionally, the final step of the derivation involves applying (28) to (48)–(50). This yields the following results:

- (51) [(48)] $\langle met(l, k), \{[speaker][0, 1]^F[addressee]\} \rangle$
 (52) [(49)] $\langle met(l, k), \{[speaker][0, .5]^F[addressee]\} \rangle$
 (53) [(50)] $\langle met(l, k), \{[speaker][0, .25]^F[addressee]\} \rangle$

Similar results are derived even in the absence of final *yo*. (54)–(56), repeated from (7)–(9), host (*su*)*pni* which conveys a higher degree of formality than final *yo*:

- (54) Lee-ka Kim-ul manna-ss-supni-ta.
Lee-NOM Kim-ACC meet-PST-PNI-DECL
'Lee met Kim.' (↪ very formal)
- (55) Lee-ka Kim-ul-yo manna-ss-supni-ta.
Lee-NOM Kim-ACC-M.YO meet-PST-PNI-DECL
'Lee met Kim.' (↪ less formal)
- (56) Lee-ka-yo Kim-ul-yo manna-ss-supni-ta.
Lee-NOM-M.YO Kim-ACC-M.YO meet-PST-PNI-DECL
'Lee met Kim.' (↪ least formal)

In order to represent the varying degrees of formality, *Is* for final *yo* and *(su)pni* ought to differ. The lexical entry for *(su)pni* is provided below:

- (57) Lexical entry for *(su)pni*
 $\llbracket (su)pni \rrbracket = ([speaker][.5, 1]^F[addressee]) : t^s$

(41) and (57) together yield the following interim output for (54)–(56):

- (58) $\llbracket (54) \rrbracket <met(l, k), \{[speaker][.5, 1]^F[addressee]\} >$
(59) $\llbracket (55) \rrbracket <met(l, k), \{[speaker][.5, 1]^F\downarrow_{+1}[addressee]\} >$
(60) $\llbracket (56) \rrbracket <met(l, k), \{[speaker][.5, 1]^F\downarrow_{+2}[addressee]\} >$

Applying (28) to (58)–(60) yields the following results:

- (61) $\llbracket (58) \rrbracket <met(l, k), \{[speaker][.5, 1]^F[addressee]\} >$
(62) $\llbracket (59) \rrbracket <met(l, k), \{[speaker][.5, .75]^F[addressee]\} >$
(63) $\llbracket (60) \rrbracket <met(l, k), \{[speaker][.5, .625]^F[addressee]\} >$

Unlike final *yo*, medial *yos* are always reliant on another formality-denoting marker. The host need not be final *yo*, but rather *(su)pni* as in (54)–(56). Medial *yos* cannot surface in the absence of final *yo* or *(su)pni*. No other discourse marker can rescue the derivation. This form of dependency suggests that medial *yo* is not an ordinary expressive:

- (64) a. Lee-ka-yo Kim-ul manna-ss-e*(-yo).
Lee-NOM-M.YO Kim-ACC meet-PST-DECL-F.YO
‘Lee met Kim.’
b. Lee-ka-yo Kim-ul manna-ss*(-supni)-ta.
Lee-NOM-M.YO Kim-ACC meet-PST-PNI-DECL
‘Lee met Kim.’

Although Choi (2021) correctly observes that medial *yos* do not induce a strengthening effect, he is not able to account for the weakening effect of medial *yos*. This is mainly because Choi assumes that both medial and final *yos* are defined with the same **I** and that their **I**s are averaged when realized together. Additionally, the analysis is unable to capture the simple strengthening effect induced by *si* shown in (1) and (2). More needs to be articulated about this data point. Moreover, it does not provide an adequate explanation as to why medial *yos* are always dependent on another expressive item whereas final *yo* is not.²⁰ Lee & Park (1991) and Yim (2012) also mention the dependency of medial *yos*. Here, I argue that the dependency arises because medial *yos* lack a fully specified **I**^F and must rely on a fully specified **I**^F elsewhere in the derivation. The lexical entry given in (41) yields this effect. It also predicts that medial *yos* are flexible enough to be realized with formality markers hosting different levels of **I**^F such as final *yo* ($[0, 1]^F$) and *(su)pni* ($[.5, 1]^F$). Here, I argue that the parasitic nature of medial *yos* sheds light on an unexplored aspect of non-descriptive semantics. Under my analysis, medial *yos* are underspecified and the restriction imposed on their distribution suggests that not all expressives are unconstrained in nature (see also Lee & Kim 2018).

4. Indexicals and Free Indirect Discourse (FID)

Before concluding, I would like to examine whether medial and final *yos* can be viewed as indexicals rather than expressives. One way to test this is to see if they can target the utterance level in Free Indirect Discourse (FID). FID, which appears in the form of an embedded clause,

²⁰ Reducing this issue to syntactic licensing such as agreement also does not seem to be desirable, since other types of expressives such as epithets do not require the same type of licensing.

reflects the speaker's perspective instead of the matrix subject's perspective by shifting the center of deixis. Only a small number of indexical pronouns are able to display this effect. This is sometimes referred to as indexical shift. A question arises as to whether *yos* are subject to indexical shift in FID. My analysis predicts that *yos* will not display this effect since they are not indexicals.

In many cases, FID is attested by shifting personal pronouns (e.g., first person pronoun → third person pronoun). The shifting of person pronouns is closely tied with the alternation between Direct Discourse (DD) and FID. One obvious difference between DD and FID is that the former employs direct quotations whereas the latter does not. An English example of shifting personal pronouns (e.g., *I* → *he*) is given in (65). The first person pronoun in (65a) refers to *John* from the perspective of the matrix subject (DD) whereas the third person pronoun in (65b) refers to *John* from the perspective of the speaker (FID):

- (65) a. “I₁ would buy some chocolate on my₁ way to work”, John₁ said. (☞ DD)
 b. He₁ would buy some chocolate on his₁ way to work, John₁ said. (☞ FID)

Note that embedding a medial *yo* under DD is not possible in Korean. For one, DD should not be grammatically integrated with the matrix clause. Also, medial *yos* do not reflect the matrix subject's perspective, but rather the speaker's. This is expected under the expressive account. Consider the following example where a medial *yo* cannot surface within DD:

- (66) John₁-i “nay₁ (/#ku₁/#caki₁)-ka(#-yo) wang-i-ta”-lako
 John-NOM 1.SG(/#3.SG.D/#3.SG.L)-NOM(#-M.YO) king-COP-DECL-C
 mal-hay-ss-e-yo.
 say-do-PST-DECL-F.YO
 • Descriptive: “I₁ am the king”, John₁ said.
 • Expressive: The speaker (/#John) is being formal to the addressee.

(67) and (68) host Korean third person pronouns, *ku* (default) and *caki* (logophoric). In both examples, the embedded medial *yo* projects out of FID and targets the utterance-level discourse. This is possible because FID reflects the speaker's perspective. Hence, formality is maintained between the speaker and the addressee of the conversation.²¹

- (67) John₁-i ku₁-ka-yo tangshin-ul silhe-ha-n-tako mal-hay-ss-e-yo.
 John-NOM 3.SG.D-NOM-M.YO 2.SG-ACC dislike-do-PRES-C say-do-PST-DECL-F.YO
 • Descriptive: He₁ dislikes you, John₁ said.
 • Expressive: The speaker (/#John) is being a bit formal to the addressee.

²¹ Philippe Schlenker (p.c.) mentions that a similar effect is observed for French *tu/vous* in DD and FID:

- a. J'ai fait un rêve étrange. Nous étions deux enfants dans la même classe, j'étais assis à vos côtés, et **vous** me disiez que **vous** aviez du mal avec votre exercice de maths.
 (Translation) I had a strange dream. The two of us were children in the same class, I was sitting next to you-formal, and you-formal told me that you-formal had trouble with your-formal math exercise.
 • “Je vis bien sûr t'aider”, **vous** répondez-je. (☞ DD)
 (Translation) “I am of course going to help you-familiar”, I replied to you-formal.
 • ?J'allais bien sûr t'aider, **vous** répondez-je. (☞ FID)
 (Translation) I was of course going to help you-familiar, I replied to you-formal.
 • ?“Je vais bien sûr **vous** aider”, **vous** répondez-je. (☞ DD)
 (Translation) “I am of course going to help you-formal”, I replied to you-formal.
 • J'allais bien sûr **vous** aider, **vous** répondez-je. (☞ FID)
 (Translation) I was of course going to help you-formal, I replied to you-formal.

- (68) John₁-i caki₁-ka-yo tangshin-ul silhe-ha-n-tako mal-hay-ss-e-yo.
 John-NOM 3.SG.L-NOM-M.YO 2.SG-ACC dislike-do-PRES-C say-do-PST-DECL-F.YO
- Descriptive: He₁ dislikes you, John₁ said.
 - Expressive: The speaker (/#John) is being a bit formal to the addressee.

English expressives such as *honkies* can be used in FID. However, it is not entirely clear whether they always project out of an embedded clause. (69) differs from (67) and (68) in that the expressive content can either reflect the attitude of the speaker or the subject of the matrix sentence:

- (69) No, really, here he₁ didn't want to meet any honkies, John₁ said.
- Descriptive: He₁ didn't want to meet white people, John₁ said.
 - Expressive: The speaker (/John) has a bad opinion about white people.

Speas & Tenny (2003) also mention that epithets such as *damned* may reflect the attitude of the speaker or the matrix subject when the sentence is embedded under a predicate of speech:

- (70) John said he phoned his damned cousin. (damned by the speaker, or the subject)
 (Speas & Tenny 2003:328)

In fact, Harris & Potts (2009) report that non-speaker-oriented readings are possible for English expressives even if they are not syntactically embedded under a predicate. In such cases, a rich contextual cue is necessary.

Although examples such as (69) and (70) seem to require further scrutiny, I wish to emphasize that Korean medial *yos* are always speaker-oriented. Simply put, they are always the widest scope-taking element in a given sentence. In fact, this is exactly the kind of result that one would expect from a non-descriptive (expressive) content.

5. Conclusion

The previous notion of repeatability requires further scrutiny. Unlike ordinary formality-denoting markers, sentence-medial *yos* show an uncommon pattern of behavior: the more *yos* you have within a sentence, the less sense of formality you get. Further, the distribution of medial *yos* suggests that they are dependent on other expressives. I have put forward the claim that medial *yos* are impoverished in terms of their expressive content. We have also seen that medial *yos* do not behave like indexicals. The implication we derive from these findings is that there are restrictions on expressives which can be explained using previously established theoretical means. By exploring this particular aspect of Korean, I hope to have shed light on the weakening effect as well as the parasitic nature of medial *yos*.

Abbreviations

1	first person	LOC	locative
2	second person	M.YO	medial <i>yo</i>
3	third person	NEG	negation, negative
ACC	accusative	NOM	nominative
ADJ	adjective	POL.PT	politeness particle
C	complementizer	PRES	present
COP	copula	PST	past
DECL	declarative	SG	singular
F.YO	final <i>yo</i>	TOP	topic

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